the following year, from which the term ‘railway time’ was derived.

So, Calcutta Time was 5 hours, 30 minutes and 21 seconds, and Bombay Time 4 hours and 51 minutes ahead of GMT. Railway companies in India had to contend with different local times, and by the end of the 1860s, the situation had become even more confusing.

> In 1870, when the Bombay-Calcutta lines linked up, shortly, to be followed by Bombay-Madras, the Bombay Presidency government suggested that Madras time be taken as standard for the railways. Why Madras? For two simple reasons: the longitude of Madras is roughly midway between those of Calcutta and Bombay, and the observatory there ran the telegraphic service which could be utilized to synchronize station times via the same time-signal system first used in Britain in 1852 to regulate railway time. Madras Time was popularized by its use in Newman’s Indian Bradshaw Timetables. [98]
>
> The autonomy enjoyed by Bombay and Calcutta resulted in both retaining local times well into the twentieth century. For the remaining part of the nineteenth century, Madras time continued to be used by all railways. Calcutta kept its own time until 1948 and to a lesser extent Bombay continued to do so unofficially until 1955. [99]
>
> Timekeeping in the railways was by means of standard-issue pendulum clocks at stations and, of course, the station master’s iconic watch or timepiece. The clocks at different stations, at least the bigger ones, were generally kept in fair synchronization by telegraphic means—a time signal was sent from the head office or the regional headquarters of a railway at a specified time every day, and the station clock was to be adjusted appropriately. This allowed trains to be run according to published timetables without the confusion of accounting for myriad local times. [10 0]

WHEN TIGERS VISITED RAIL STATIONS

Three Anecdotes

A Royal Bengal tiger waiting at a station

> Though the Assam Bengal Railway did bring about increased settlements in the hills, the area remained thinly populated even till the mid-twentieth century. An old railway hand, who was the station master at Ditokcherra in the 1960s had this tale to relate: ‘It was a lonely spot with a tribal village about 5 km away and I could stay there only because I was young and foolish. Trains used to pass at night and we had to wait for them on the platform in order to hand over the lukka (a ringed loop exchanged as a signal). Once, late at night, my assistant was waiting at the platform with the lukka flare when he saw something else waiting beside him. It was a Royal Bengal tiger, perhaps awaiting the arrival of the train!’ [101]

‘Tiger eating station master on front porch’